MENTAL HEALTH CONTENT

Expanded Chapter 02

Recognizing Emotions and Responding to Them

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Audience: General adult readers and older adolescents with appropriate support. **Suggested study time:** 35-50 minutes plus optional exercises.

Purpose: This standalone chapter teaches readers to identify, understand, express and respond to emotions using safe, practical approaches. It is exclusively about mental health and emotional wellbeing.

Editorial status: Evidence-informed original educational material. This chapter has not yet received clinical review, Kinyarwanda/French localization, accessibility testing or approval for public release. It does not diagnose or provide individual therapy.

Safety: If you are in immediate danger or may harm yourself or another person, seek urgent in-person assistance or local emergency care. Local contact details must be checked before publication.

Learning goals

- Identify common emotions and explain how emotions, thoughts, physical sensations and actions interact.
- Recognize that emotions have useful information but do not always represent facts or instructions.
- Practise naming feelings and choosing safe responses to them.
- Distinguish emotional expression from harmful behavior, suppression and avoidance.
- Apply simple grounding, self-kindness and communication skills without treating them as a replacement for healthcare.
- Recognize when emotional difficulties warrant routine or urgent professional assistance.

2.1 What are emotions?

Emotions are experiences that can involve feelings, bodily changes, thoughts, urges and outward behavior. They often arise when we interpret an event as important: something feels threatening, unfair, disappointing, joyful, surprising or meaningful. For example, after hearing good news a person may feel delighted, smile and want to tell someone; after receiving criticism the same person may feel embarrassed, notice tension and want to withdraw.

Emotions are not signs of moral success or failure. Anger does not make a person dangerous; sadness does not make them weak; fear does not prove that a threat is present. What matters is how a person understands their experience and how they choose to behave. Emotions can be mixed or unclear: someone may feel proud about a new opportunity and worried about the responsibility at the same time.

Different people show emotions differently, and cultural expectations may shape which feelings are openly discussed. Not showing an emotion does not mean the person does not experience it. Equally, another person cannot reliably identify a hidden feeling merely from facial expression or behavior.

2.2 Emotional experiences: more than one feeling

Emotion	What it may signal	Example of a helpful response
Joy	Something valued or enjoyable has happened	Notice and enjoy it; share if you wish
Sadness	Loss, disappointment or unmet needs	Allow the feeling; consider comfort or support
Fear	A possible threat or uncertainty	Check present safety and available options
Anger	A perceived injustice or boundary issue	Pause, examine the situation and respond safely
Shame	Concern about negative judgment or self-worth	Challenge harsh labels and seek understanding
Guilt	Concern about a specific action	Consider repair when appropriate, without self-punishment
Loneliness	A need for connection or belonging	Reach out to safe people or services

These examples are possibilities, not fixed meanings. A feeling can have several causes. Someone might be irritable because of stress, lack of sleep, illness or something else entirely. It can help to ask, "What else may be happening?" before drawing conclusions.

2.3 How emotions, thoughts, the body and behavior connect

Imagine an adult whose supervisor has asked for a meeting. The event is simple: "There is a meeting tomorrow." One possible thought is, "I must be in trouble." That interpretation may bring fear, tight shoulders and an urge to avoid the meeting. Another thought could be, "I do not know what this is about yet." The person may still feel nervous but be more able to prepare and attend.

In this example, the event, interpretation, feeling, physical sensation and action influence one another. People cannot always choose the first emotion they experience, but they may be able to choose a next step. A realistic response could be to gather facts, practise a calming skill or ask for clarification. It is not necessary to force a positive thought or deny a genuine problem.

2.4 Naming an emotion: a practical starting point

Noticing and naming a feeling can create a small space between an experience and an action. WHO stress-management materials use related skills of noticing, naming and returning attention to what matters. The goal is not to eliminate emotions; it is to become more aware and less automatically pulled by them. [1]

A five-part check-in: (1) Pause briefly if it is safe. (2) Notice what is happening in your body and thoughts. (3) Use a simple label such as "worried," "hurt," "frustrated" or "not sure." (4) Ask what you might need: information, rest, connection, protection or professional guidance. (5) Choose one safe next action.

A person who cannot name the feeling is not failing the exercise. "Something feels difficult" is a valid starting point. Some people find writing or talking easier than identifying emotions silently. Others prefer drawing, movement or quiet time.

2.5 Emotions and needs: listening without obeying every urge

Emotions can direct attention to important needs, but the first urge may not be wise. Anger may reflect a wish to be respected, yet shouting or striking someone would still be harmful. Fear may encourage caution, but avoidance of every uncertain situation can gradually narrow daily life. Sadness may signal a need for comfort, but withdrawing completely for weeks may leave someone without support.

Consider two separate questions: "What information might this emotion contain?" and "What response would protect my wellbeing and respect other people?" The answers may be different. A safe response to anger might be to ask for space, clarify a boundary, seek mediation or leave an escalating situation.

2.6 Emotional regulation: what it means and what it does not

Emotional regulation refers to ways people influence their emotional responses and behavior. It does not mean staying calm all the time, suppressing tears, or never expressing anger. Regulation can include changing a situation, shifting attention, considering other explanations, accepting a feeling, asking for support, and responding according to personal values.

Strategies depend on context. When a person is unsafe, finding protection may matter more than using a relaxation technique. When emotions arise from exhaustion, sleep or practical support may be necessary. When distress is severe or persistent, professional care may be more appropriate than self-help alone.

2.7 Skill A: grounding in the present

Grounding is a way to reconnect with the current environment when overwhelmed by thoughts or strong feelings. It is optional. WHO describes grounding as noticing thoughts and feelings, connecting with the body, and refocusing on the surroundings. [1]

- Choose a position that feels safe; keep your eyes open if you prefer.
- Notice the contact between your feet and the floor or between your body and the chair.
- Quietly identify two or three things you can see or hear.
- Notice one simple activity you can do next, such as drinking water or returning to a task.
- Stop if this brings increased discomfort, dissociation or a sense of danger. Choose another supportive action or seek help.

You do not need to breathe deeply, relive a painful memory or complete the exercise perfectly. For some people, focusing on the body is uncomfortable; noticing external objects may feel safer. Grounding is a coping tool, not a cure for a mental health condition.

2.8 Skill B: allowing feelings without surrendering to them

Trying to force a painful emotion away may sometimes intensify struggle. A different approach is to acknowledge that it is present: "I notice sadness" or "This is a difficult moment." WHO describes a related skill called "making room" for difficult thoughts and feelings. [1]

For a brief practice, notice a manageable feeling without investigating it in depth. Say, if useful, "I can notice this feeling and still choose what I do next." Return attention to something safe and ordinary. If the practice increases distress, stop. People who experience trauma-related symptoms or intense dissociation may need tailored clinical guidance rather than independent exercises.

2.9 Skill C: responding to self-critical thoughts

When upset, people sometimes criticize themselves: "I am useless," "I always fail," or "I should never feel this way." Such statements are thoughts, not proven facts. A more balanced response might be, "I made a mistake; I can decide what to learn and what help I need." Self-kindness does not require excusing harmful actions or pretending there are no consequences.

Try speaking to yourself as you would speak to a respected person facing the same challenge. Notice one specific difficulty, acknowledge it without insults, and identify a constructive next step. WHO includes self-kindness among its everyday stress-management skills. [1]

2.10 Skill D: expressing feelings in a safe conversation

Expressing feelings can support understanding and connection, but disclosure should be voluntary and directed toward a safe person. A simple communication pattern is: "When [situation] happened, I felt [emotion]. I would appreciate [specific request]." For example: "When our plans changed without warning, I felt frustrated. Could we discuss changes earlier next time?"

This phrasing helps describe experience without asserting that the other person intended harm. It does not guarantee agreement, and it should not be used to confront someone who could react violently. In unsafe circumstances, seek support or a safer communication channel rather than attempting a direct discussion.

2.11 Skill E: pause before acting on intense emotion

A strong emotion can create urgency. When possible, a brief pause may prevent choices that lead to regret. First, check whether you are physically safe. Next, notice the impulse without acting immediately. If appropriate, step away from an argument, drink water, or ask for time. Then consider what matters most: safety, dignity, fairness, relationships or solving the practical problem.

This technique does not mean delaying an essential safety action. When facing immediate danger, prioritise getting to safety and contacting appropriate help. When there is risk of harming someone, disengage from the situation if safe and obtain urgent support.

2.12 Practical examples in daily life

Example 1: A learner receives disappointing results. The learner feels ashamed and thinks, "Everyone will judge me." They may name embarrassment, talk with a trusted educator and make a realistic study plan. The goal is not to deny disappointment but to reduce self-blame and find a way forward.

Example 2: A caregiver feels angry and exhausted. An adult caring for relatives feels irritation when interrupted. Rather than responding harshly, they acknowledge fatigue and ask whether someone can share a task. If no help is available, they may need external practical support, not simply advice to remain patient.

Example 3: A young adult feels isolated. Someone who recently moved to another district misses familiar people. They recognize loneliness and explore a safe way to reconnect, such as messaging a trusted friend or attending an activity that suits their interests. If withdrawal and low mood persist, professional support may be useful.

Example 4: A person feels frightened after a conflict. Before considering emotional exercises, they ask whether the situation is physically safe. Where there is danger, they prioritize protection, safe contacts and appropriate services. Emotional coping is not a substitute for physical safety.

These are fictional teaching situations, not actual case histories. Local reviewers should check that examples are respectful, understandable and relevant across Rwanda.

2.13 Common misunderstandings

Misunderstanding	More accurate understanding
"Negative" emotions should always be removed.	Unpleasant emotions may carry information and are part of life; safe responses matter.
Feeling angry means acting aggressively.	An emotion and an action are different. Anger can be managed without harm.
A calm appearance means a person is fine.	People may experience strong emotions privately or express them differently.
A coping exercise always works.	Some techniques help some people in some settings; adaptation and support may be needed.
Opening up to anyone is always healthy.	Choose safe, trustworthy people. Privacy and personal choice matter.

2.14 When should someone seek additional help?

Consider support from a qualified healthcare or mental health professional when emotional distress continues, becomes harder to manage, disrupts sleep or functioning, causes increasing isolation, or leads to harmful coping patterns. Also seek assessment for symptoms that may have a medical cause, such as substantial unexplained changes in energy or new physical problems. Asking for help early is reasonable; a person does not need a diagnosis to deserve support.

Urgent help: If emotions are accompanied by thoughts of suicide, intent to self-harm, threats of serious harm toward others, severe confusion, inability to maintain safety, or other immediate dangers, seek urgent in-person assistance. Contact verified local emergency services or go to an emergency department when possible. This educational document is not a crisis response service.

2.15 Guided self-reflection worksheet

Complete this only if it feels comfortable. Do not record identifying or sensitive details if the worksheet could be seen by others. It is not a screening or diagnostic tool.

- **Situation:** Describe an ordinary recent event in one sentence, without names or private details.

- **Feeling:** What emotion or combination of emotions did you notice? "Not sure" is acceptable.
- **Body:** Did you notice tension, restlessness, tiredness or another sensation? You may skip this.
- **Thought:** What was going through your mind? Could there be other explanations?
- **Need:** Did you need rest, clarity, connection, safety, practical assistance or something else?
- **Response:** What is one safe next step you could choose?
- **Support:** Who or what could help if the situation continues?

Optional seven-day practice: Once a day, note one emotion, one possible cause and one safe response. Do not score yourself or aim to feel happy every day. If repeated monitoring makes you more anxious or distressed, discontinue it.

2.16 Knowledge check with explained answers

1. True or false: Feeling afraid always means immediate danger. **Answer: False.** Fear may help identify threats, but it may also arise in anticipation or uncertainty. Check the facts and your current safety.

2. Can someone feel two emotions at once? Answer: Yes. For instance, relief and sadness may occur together after a difficult change.

3. Does emotional regulation mean never crying? Answer: No. It is about responding safely and flexibly, not suppressing every emotional expression.

4. If grounding makes someone more distressed, should they continue? Answer: No. They can stop, choose another supportive activity and seek appropriate advice if needed.

5. When is professional support appropriate? Answer: Whenever distress is persistent, worsening, impairing daily life or difficult to manage, and immediately when serious safety risks are present.

2.17 Chapter summary

Emotions are complex human experiences that can influence thoughts, bodily sensations and actions. No emotion by itself defines a person. Learning to notice, name and respond to emotions can support everyday wellbeing. Helpful responses include checking safety, choosing practical next steps, communicating with safe people, treating oneself with dignity and accessing professional support when needed. Self-help tools are optional supports, not substitutes for treatment or protection.

2.18 Terms and meanings

Term	Plain-language meaning
Emotion	An experience that can include feeling, body responses, thoughts and urges.
Emotional awareness	Recognizing and naming what one is experiencing.
Emotional regulation	Ways of responding to emotions and guiding behavior in context.
Grounding	Returning attention to the present environment when overwhelmed.
Self-kindness	Responding to oneself with care rather than insults or harsh judgment.
Psychological distress	Difficult emotions or thoughts; not automatically a disorder.

Evidence and editorial references

[1] World Health Organization (2020). *Doing What Matters in Times of Stress: An Illustrated Guide.* WHO, ISBN 978-92-4-000391-0. https://tdr.who.int/home/our-work/global-engagement/9789240003927

[2] World Health Organization. *Mental health: strengthening our response.* General context for wellbeing, risk and protective conditions. https://www.who.int/news-room/fact-sheets/detail/mental-health-strengthening-our-response

This chapter is original explanatory material informed by the above resources, not a reproduction of WHO exercises or a clinical protocol. The examples, communication pattern and worksheets are educational adaptations and should be clinically assessed prior to public use.

Pre-publication approval checklist

- Clinical reviewer verifies definitions, coping suggestions, warning signs and referral language.
- Safety specialist confirms the advice does not unintentionally increase risk in unsafe situations.
- Rwanda-based language reviewers validate terminology and examples in English, Kinyarwanda and French.
- Accessible formats and reading-level tests are completed with intended users.
- Emergency and routine referral contacts are verified, dated and maintained.
- A named editor approves final version and schedules review after major evidence changes.